

MONROE ELEMENTARY

Brand Guidelines

Visual identity, voice, and design standards
260 Madrid Street · San Francisco, CA · SFUSD

2026

Contents

1. Who We Are

Mission

Monroe Elementary is a joyful, multilingual public school in San Francisco's Excelsior neighborhood. We serve a diverse community of families — in English, Spanish, and Cantonese — and are committed to building a school where every child belongs, every family is welcomed, and the community takes care of each other.

Core Values

- Community over institution — we center families, not bureaucracy
- Liberation and equity — anti-racist, culturally affirming, justice-minded
- Radical welcome — every family deserves access, information, and belonging
- Social-emotional learning — the whole child matters
- Multilingual identity — English, Spanish, and Cantonese are equally honored
- Mutual aid — we look out for each other

Our Audiences

PRIMARY

- Current Monroe families (caregivers, parents, guardians)
- Students

SECONDARY

- Prospective families considering enrollment
- Community partners and volunteers
- SFUSD staff and administration

2. Voice & Tone

Our voice is the personality behind everything we write and say. It stays consistent across all communication. Our tone shifts depending on context — warmer and more casual in community messages, more informative and clear in resource documents.

Voice Principles

Warm and Direct

We speak like a trusted neighbor, not a government office. We get to the point without being cold. We say "We've got you" not "Please be advised."

Community-First

The school exists for its families. Language centers the reader: "You can find..." not "Parents are encouraged to..." We avoid institutional distance.

Hopeful and Real

We acknowledge difficulty honestly while holding space for possibility. We don't paper over hard realities with empty positivity, but we always point toward what's possible.

Multilingual by Default

All primary communications are available in English, Spanish, and Cantonese. Translation is not an afterthought — it is baked into every content plan from the start.

Inclusive and Liberatory

We use gender-neutral language. We do not center whiteness or default assumptions of ability, housing status, or immigration status. We reflect the full humanity of our community.

Tone by Context

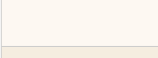
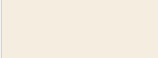
Context	Tone	Example
Homepage / hero	Confident, welcoming, energetic	<i>"We take care of each other."</i>
Community Hub	Warm, practical, non-judgmental	<i>"Need something? We've got you."</i>
Event announcements	Friendly, clear, action-oriented	<i>"Join us Thursday — food provided."</i>
Resource documents	Clear, accessible, plain language	<i>"To apply, bring two forms of ID."</i>
Fundraising	Gratitude-first, community-minded	<i>"Every dollar stays at Monroe."</i>
Emergency / urgent	Calm, clear, direct	<i>"School is closed tomorrow, May 20."</i>

Voice Do's and Don'ts

DO	DON'T
✓ Use plain language families can act on	✗ Use bureaucratic or legalistic language
✓ "We've got you. Need something? Just ask."	✗ "Families are encouraged to avail themselves of..."
✓ Center the reader: "You can..."	✗ Center the institution: "Monroe provides..."
✓ Acknowledge difficulty honestly	✗ Minimize or paper over real challenges
✓ Use "caregivers" or "families" (inclusive)	✗ Default to "parents" (excludes guardians, grandparents)
✓ Translate all primary content upfront	✗ Add "Translation available upon request" as a workaround

3. Color Palette

Monroe's palette is warm, vibrant, and rooted in the community's energy. Cream and Ink form the neutral foundation. Monarch Orange is the primary brand accent. The supporting palette of Cyan, Marigold, Magenta, Poppy, Jade, and Plum are used for Community Hub sections, labels, and decorative accents.

Swatch	Name	Hex	CSS Variable	Primary Role
	Monarch Orange	#E26A1F	--monarch	Primary brand accent, CTAs, active states
	Ink	#1A1410	--ink	Body text, borders, shadows
	Cream	#FDF8F2	--cream	Page background
	Cream 2	#F5EDE0	--cream2	Secondary bg, tab bar, hover states
	Cyan	#2BB8D4	--cyan	Get Connected tab accent
	Marigold	#F0A82E	--marigold	Secondary accent, ParentSquare button
	Magenta	#D83A6D	--magenta	Community Care tab accent
	Poppy Red	#D8392E	--poppy	Label text, alert, kicker dots
	Jade	#4D8C5C	--jade	Resources tab accent
	Plum	#7C3F88	--plum	Lunch Menu tab accent

Color Usage Rules

Monarch Orange — Primary Accent

- Use for primary CTAs (buttons, links that drive action)
- Active nav states, hover color for text links
- Kicker text, section labels, brush stroke underlines
- Never use as a large background behind dark text without checking contrast

Ink — Text & Borders

- Default for all body copy, headings, borders, and box shadows
- Used at full opacity (#1A1410) for primary text
- Used at partial opacity (rgba) for subtle dividers, secondary text

Cream & Cream 2 — Backgrounds

- Cream (#FDF8F2) is the default page background

- Cream 2 (#F5EDE0) is used for secondary panels, tab bars, hover states
- Never place small light text on cream — contrast is insufficient

Community Hub Accent Colors

Each of the five Community Hub tabs has a dedicated accent color. These colors should only appear in the context of their section — they are not general-purpose brand colors.

#	Tab	Color	Purpose
i	Get Connected	Cyan / #2BB8D4	Social connection, community events, outreach
ii	Community Care	Magenta / #D83A6D	Mutual aid, equity fund, support services
iii	Resources	Jade / #4D8C5C	Curated family resources, guides, links
iv	Volunteer	Monarch / #E26A1F	Volunteer opportunities, sign-ups
v	Lunch Menu	Plum / #7C3F88	Weekly school lunch menu

Color Do's and Don'ts

DO	DON'T
✓ Use Monarch Orange for primary CTAs and active states	✗ Use multiple accent colors in the same UI element
✓ Maintain contrast: dark text on light, light text on dark	✗ Place cream text on white or very light backgrounds
✓ Use Hub accent colors only within their section	✗ Use Magenta or Plum as general brand colors
✓ Use ink borders to create definition between sections	✗ Use gradients or drop shadows (off-brand)

4. Typography

Primary Typeface — Outfit

Outfit is our primary typeface, used for all headings, body copy, navigation, labels, and UI elements. It is a clean, geometric sans-serif with a friendly, modern character.

Usage	Weight	Size Range	Notes
Hero Headings	900 (Black)	52–88px	Tight tracking (–0.03em), used for main page titles
Page Headings (H1)	900 (Black)	36–52px	Section-level titles, tight tracking
Subheadings (H2–H3)	700–800 (Bold)	22–32px	Section labels and sub-sections
Body Copy	400 (Regular)	15–18px	Line height 1.55–1.7 for readability
Labels / Kickers	800 (ExtraBold)	11–13px	All-caps, letter-spacing 0.18–0.22em
Navigation	700 (Bold)	13px	All-caps, letter-spacing 0.04em
Buttons / CTAs	700–800 (Bold)	12px	All-caps, letter-spacing 0.06em

Accent Typeface — ZCOOL XiaoWei / Noto Serif TC

For Chinese-language content, we use ZCOOL XiaoWei as the display typeface and Noto Serif TC as the body and fallback. These are applied via the .f-zh utility class.

- Use for all Cantonese/Simplified Chinese content
- Do not apply to English or Spanish text
- Load via Google Fonts with the Outfit family for performance

Typography Do's and Don'ts

DO	DON'T
✓ Use Outfit for all English and Spanish text	✗ Use system fonts or other sans-serifs for primary UI
✓ Use tight negative tracking (–0.02 to –0.03em) on large headings	✗ Use positive letter-spacing on large display type
✓ Use wide positive tracking (0.18–0.22em) on small all-caps labels	✗ Use all-caps without letter-spacing (hard to read)
✓ Maintain a clear type hierarchy (hero → heading → body)	✗ Use more than 3 type sizes in a single section

✓ Use ZCOOL XiaoWei / Noto Serif TC for Chinese content

✗ Use Outfit for Chinese characters

5. Design Elements

Monroe's visual language is warm, handcrafted, and energetic. Several recurring design elements create a cohesive look across all pages.

Flat Box Shadows

Buttons and key UI elements use flat, offset solid shadows — no blur, no gradient. This creates a bold, tactile, print-like quality.

- Standard shadow: 3–4px offset, 0px blur, Ink color (#1A1410)
- On hover: translate the element 2px down/right, reduce shadow to 1–2px
- Never use CSS drop-shadow blur or soft shadows

Brush Stroke Underlines

Key words in hero headings are underlined with an SVG brush stroke using feTurbulence and feDisplacementMap filters. This creates a hand-painted, organic feel.

- Color: Monarch Orange (#E26A1F), full opacity
- Applied to the most emotionally resonant word or phrase in the hero
- Unique seeds for each page — no two brush strokes are identical
- Must be responsive: SVG scales with text via width: 100%

Rainbow Stripe

A horizontal stripe of all brand colors appears as a decorative accent — typically at the top of key sections or as a footer divider. Each color segment is equal width.

Color order: Poppy · Monarch · Marigold · Jade · Cyan · Plum · Magenta (repeating)

- Standard height: 6px on most pages; thinner variants (3px) in compact contexts
- Used sparingly — one or two instances per page

Grain Overlay

A subtle noise texture (grain.js) is applied as a fixed overlay across the entire site at mix-blend-mode: multiply. This adds warmth and a slightly analog quality to the otherwise digital design.

- Opacity: 1 (controlled by the SVG filter, not CSS opacity)
- Do not increase or decrease the grain — it's calibrated for the cream background

Ink Borders

Section dividers, card outlines, and UI boundaries use 1.5px solid Ink borders. These create clean, legible structure without shadows.

- Standard: 1.5px solid #1A1410 (full ink)
- Subtle dividers: use `rgba(26,20,16, 0.12–0.2)`
- Dashed borders: used for internal footer dividers

Decorative Motifs

Monroe uses culturally resonant visual motifs — butterflies, Chinese lattice patterns, and papel picado-inspired shapes. These appear as light background textures or small accent illustrations.

- Butterflies: brand illustrations in black silhouette, can be tinted with CSS filter to brand colors
- Chinese lattice: used as a subtle background texture at low opacity (0.04)
- Half-circles: geometric decorative accents at section edges
- Always treat motifs as secondary — never let them compete with content

Buttons

Two primary button styles:

Button	Background	Use For	Hover State
Primary (Give)	Monarch Orange	Main CTA, donation, high-priority actions	Translate 2px, shadow collapses
Secondary (Tour)	Cream / transparent	Secondary actions, navigation support	Background darkens to Ink, text goes Cream
ParentSquare	Marigold	External platform link, utility bar	Background shifts to Monarch, text goes Cream

6. Community Hub Identity

The Community Hub is Monroe's most distinctive feature — a multilingual, community-centered resource portal. It has its own visual sub-identity within the Monroe brand.

Hub Tagline

"We take care of each other."

Need something? We've got you. Want to help? We'll find a match.

Hub Values

- Free — all services and resources are available at no cost
- Confidential — information shared stays within the community
- Multilingual — fully available in English, Spanish, and Cantonese
- Non-judgmental — every family's situation is valid
- Community-built — driven by what Monroe families actually need

Five Sections

#	Tab	Color	Purpose
i	Get Connected	Cyan / #2BB8D4	Social connection, community events, outreach
ii	Community Care	Magenta / #D83A6D	Mutual aid, equity fund, support services
iii	Resources	Jade / #4D8C5C	Curated family resources, guides, links
iv	Volunteer	Monarch / #E26A1F	Volunteer opportunities, sign-ups
v	Lunch Menu	Plum / #7C3F88	Weekly school lunch menu

Hub Voice

The Hub speaks more softly than the main site — less energetic, more held. The tone is that of a caring neighbor who knows the community well.

- "Need something? We've got you." — not "Apply for assistance below."
- "Want to help? We'll find a match." — not "Volunteer opportunities are available."
- Language is trauma-informed and non-stigmatizing
- Instructions are clear and step-by-step — families in stress need low cognitive load

7. Multilingual Standards

Monroe is a multilingual school and brand. Language access is a right, not a courtesy. These standards ensure we honor that across all communications.

Languages

- English (primary)
- Spanish (es) — second language for a significant portion of Monroe families
- Cantonese/Traditional Chinese (zh) — third language, displayed in ZCOOL XiaoWei / Noto Serif TC

Standards

- All primary web pages must have content available in all three languages via Google Translate integration
- High-stakes content (enrollment, Hub resources, emergency notices) must be human-translated, not machine-translated
- Language switcher is always visible in the utility bar at the top of every page
- Language labels use each language's own script: English · Español · 中文
- Chinese label uses ZCOOL XiaoWei font and Magenta color in the utility bar
- Spanish label uses Marigold color in the utility bar
- Translation suppresses Google Translate banner (handled via CSS)

Multilingual Do's and Don'ts

DO	DON'T
✓ Translate all primary content before publishing	✗ Launch new content in English only and add translations later
✓ Use human translation for Hub resources and enrollment	✗ Rely on machine translation for high-stakes content
✓ Display language labels in their own scripts	✗ Write "Chinese" instead of "中文"
✓ Design layouts that work in all three languages (text expansion)	✗ Design tight layouts that break when Spanish or Chinese text is longer

8. Web Implementation

Monroe's website is a static HTML site. These standards ensure visual and technical consistency across all pages.

Page Structure

- Every page includes: Utility Bar → Masthead/Nav → Page Content → Footer
- Utility bar: address, phone, ParentSquare button, language switcher
- Masthead: logo (200px wide), centered navigation, Tour + Give buttons
- Footer: logo, address, link columns, legal/copyright bar
- Mobile nav: hamburger button → full-screen overlay with all links

CSS Custom Properties

All colors are defined as CSS custom properties in `:root` and referenced throughout. Never hardcode hex values in page-specific styles — always use the variable.

Variable	Value	Usage
<code>--cream</code>	<code>#FDF8F2</code>	Page background
<code>--cream2</code>	<code>#F5EDE0</code>	Secondary bg, tab bars, hover
<code>--ink</code>	<code>#1A1410</code>	Text, borders, shadows
<code>--monarch</code>	<code>#E26A1F</code>	Primary accent, CTAs
<code>--cyan</code>	<code>#2BB8D4</code>	Get Connected
<code>--marigold</code>	<code>#F0A82E</code>	Secondary accent, ParentSquare
<code>--magenta</code>	<code>#D83A6D</code>	Community Care
<code>--poppy</code>	<code>#D8392E</code>	Labels, alerts
<code>--jade</code>	<code>#4D8C5C</code>	Resources
<code>--plum</code>	<code>#7C3F88</code>	Lunch Menu

Fonts (Google Fonts)

Load via Google Fonts CDN with `display=swap` for performance:

- Outfit: weights 300, 400, 500, 600, 700, 800, 900
- ZCOOL XiaoWei: display only
- Noto Serif TC: weights 400, 500, 600, 700, 900
- Always preconnect to `fonts.googleapis.com` and `fonts.gstatic.com`

Navigation

- Active page: bottom border in Cyan on the nav link
- Hover: color shifts to Monarch Orange (no underline)
- Dropdowns: 260px min-width, 1.5px solid Ink border, 5px flat box-shadow
- Home is always the first nav item
- Give button appears in the masthead actions area, not in the nav

Accessibility

- All images must have alt text or `aria-hidden="true"` for decorative images
- Color is never the sole means of conveying information
- Interactive elements have visible focus states
- Minimum text contrast ratio: 4.5:1 for body, 3:1 for large text
- Mobile nav overlay is fully keyboard navigable

Performance

- Non-hero images use `loading="lazy"`
- Google Translate script loads async
- Images should be compressed and appropriately sized before upload
- Grain overlay uses a fixed-position SVG (grain.js) — do not duplicate

9. Imagery Guidelines

Photography

- Authentic community photography preferred over stock images
- Images should reflect the full diversity of Monroe families
- Warm, natural lighting — avoid cold or overly clinical looks
- Candid moments over posed — community energy over performance
- When student images are used, ensure proper media release consent

Illustrations & Icons

- Butterfly motifs: black silhouette, can be tinted to brand colors via CSS filter
- Cultural patterns (Chinese lattice) used as subtle texture only
- Icons: thin-stroke, consistent weight — avoid filled or cartoonish styles
- All decorative images must include `aria-hidden="true"`

What to Avoid

DO	DON'T
✓ Use authentic photos of Monroe students and families	✗ Use generic stock photography of children
✓ Show diversity across race, family structure, ability	✗ Default to imagery that centers white, nuclear families
✓ Use images that are warm and community-centered	✗ Use clinical, institutional, or test-focused imagery
✓ Scale decorative motifs to complement content	✗ Let decorative elements overpower or distract from content

10. Quick Reference Card

School Name	Monroe Elementary School
Tagline	"We take care of each other."
Address	260 Madrid Street, San Francisco, CA 94112
Phone	(415) 469-4736
District	San Francisco Unified School District (SFUSD)
Languages	English · Español · 中文
Primary Font	Outfit (Google Fonts), weights 300–900
Chinese Font	ZCOOL XiaoWei / Noto Serif TC
Brand Orange	#E26A1F (--monarch)
Dark/Ink	#1A1410 (--ink)
Background	#FDF8F2 (--cream)
Primary CTA	Monarch Orange button, flat 3–4px ink shadow
Hover pattern	Translate 2px, shadow collapses; or color → Monarch
Border style	1.5px solid #1A1410 (or rgba at reduced opacity)
Shadow style	Flat offset, no blur — 3–5px X/Y, ink color